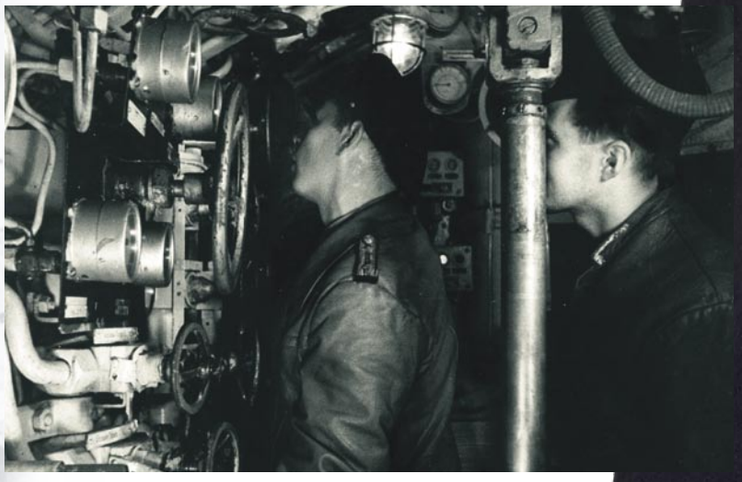
ATTACK AND DEFENCE

In the early years of the war, U-boats attacked merchant convoys on the surface at night, exploiting their good surface speed and low profile to slip through the screen of escort warships and strike at the heart of the convoy. The watch officer on deck relayed targeting instructions to the torpedo crew through a voice tube. Later in the war, as the enemy's radar improved, U-boats were increasingly forced to attack submerged. Naturally, coming under attack themselves was the most nerve-racking experience for a U-boat crew. If spotted by an enemy warship, their best chance was to crash-dive, which took around 30 seconds. They would then hope to avoid detection by sonar or hydrophones, maintaining strict silence as their own hydrophones picked up the sound of an escort vessel drawing close. Being depth-charged was a severe test of the nerves. Even a near miss could cause leaks and other damage requiring all hands to the pumps. Cowering under the sea was such a demoralizing experience that, if attacked by aircraft, U-boat captains often preferred to take their chance on fighting back rather than diving.

Up to 1943, U-boat losses were low and sinkings of merchant ships were common. But times changed. As Allied anti-submarine warfare techniques improved radically, life became hell for the U-boat men. As losses mounted the elite veterans were killed off and new U-boats were rushed into service with hastily trained crews. Late in the war, the introduction of the Type XXI U-boat at last gave the Germans a genuine submarine – a vessel that could patrol at good speed under water for long periods. But it arrived too late and in too small numbers to affect the course of the war.



Matrose service suit
An ordinary seaman, or Matrose, was issued with a blue service suit. When at sea, U-boat crewmen often wore working suits or even informal check shirts.



Engine room
A U-boat's engine room was a narrow passageway running between two diesel engines. The latter propelled the boat when it was on the surface; when it was underwater, it relied on relatively weak electric motors.